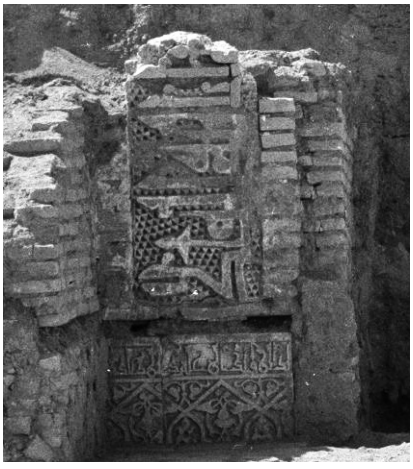


Figure 5.7 *Detail of Figure 5.6, Ghazni, palace of Mas'ud III, juxtaposition of Ghaznavid- and Shansabani-period revetments.*

were not limited to the additions of large, bold terracotta epigraphy towering above their predecessors' more refined marble dadoes. The 1950s Italian excavations at the site also unearthed approximately 160 glazed tiles, square or polygonal in shape, with molded decorative motifs. The glazes on the tiles were varied, their colors including green, yellow, brown, red, blue, and turquoise of various hues. The molded decoration encompassed a wide array of geometric, floral-arabesque, zoomorphic, and pseudo-epigraphic motifs. The relatively small number of these glazed tiles led the archaeologists to suggest they were used as punctual decoration, inspired by grid patterns on woven textiles of the time, which framed various floral, geometric, and animal motifs. Given the tiles' retrieval from the uppermost layers of the Ghazna palace, as well as a few at the House of Lusterware, Scerrato[26] opined that the tiles were manufactured most probably in the late twelfth and early thirteenth centuries, thanks to a local tile industry that had apparently survived 'Ala' al-Din's onslaught, the Oghüz occupation, until the definitive Shansabani conquest of the city. Thus, the new Shansabani sultan of Ghazna, seeing personified before him the value of monumental and distinctive imperial patronage, was reviving the glory of his newly acquired "capital" in his own way (cf. below and Chapter 6).

Bust

The expansive stretch southwestward from Ghazna to the citadel and settlement of Bust had long marked a busy thoroughfare. At least from Parthian times or the early centuries of the Common Era, the town of Bust and its imposing citadel had functioned as an important waystation, from whence branched a northward route into Zamindawar, touching